

SPOILER-FREE PREVIEW

A family story under pressure.

Read an opening scene and one genuine exhibit from the expanded narrative edition. This preview contains no solution or hidden identity disclosure.

Inside the complete game: a sustained character story, an archive of inspectable records, working pages, progressive hints, an evidence-cited solution, and an expanded aftermath.

Play alone or investigate together. Every required clue is in the supplied papers. Print in grayscale or use the PDF bookmarks and catalog. No host or outside research is needed.

Player file: 30 pages. Preview pages are selected excerpts; their archive and story labels match the full edition.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The supper kept warm

Before the opening brief

Margaret had left the warming oven open. By morning there was nothing in it worth saving, but shutting the door seemed too much like agreeing that the meal was over.

Henry stood beside the table with his cap crushed between his hands. He was old enough to work at the works and young enough to look at his mother whenever something had to be decided. She wanted him to say something useful. Instead he asked whether she had slept.

"Have you?" she said.

He shook his head. She put a cup in front of him. It was easier to be angry while doing something kind.

The telegram lay beside Eleanor's place. Margaret had read it until the capital letters ceased to resemble her daughter's voice. Gone away. Do not look. She could imagine Eleanor going somewhere without permission. That was different from believing she had sent this message. Her daughter was twenty-five; Margaret knew she could not make a disappearance impossible merely by calling it unlike her.

"James says she went," Henry said.

"I know what James says."

He looked down. She heard what she had done: made him choose between an absent sister and the brother he would have to face at work. She touched his sleeve.

"Tell them what you know. Not what will make me feel better."

When George arrived, his expression was the careful one he used for estate business. He put his papers on the table, then moved them away from Eleanor's plate. Margaret watched that small correction. For sixteen months, since Samuel's death, George had been the person who knew what had to be signed and what could wait. This morning she needed him to admit that he might not know.

"She asked you to listen," she said.

"I intended to."

"Then start with what she left here."

George reached for the portfolio of copies. Margaret did not let go at once. Some part of her still wished Eleanor had left the old registers alone. She hated herself for the wish, and hated that it had survived the night.

Henry drew his chair closer. Nobody ate. The papers were spread between people who loved the same missing woman and no longer knew whether they could trust the same brother.

Missing-person inquiry

Cincinnati / report opened 19 June 1912, 7.30 a.m.

Subject	Details
Name	Eleanor Mae Hart / age 25
Residence	1634 Lincoln Avenue, Walnut Hills
Destination	Hart Tool & Pattern Works / 418 Eastern Avenue

Mrs. Margaret Hart reports that her daughter left home at about 4.30 yesterday afternoon, Tuesday, 18 June. She carried a brown paper portfolio tied with blue cotton tape. She said she was taking family papers to the works and would be home for supper at six.

She wore a pale blouse, dark skirt and a straw hat with a black band. She took neither a travelling bag nor a change of clothes. A telegram was delivered at 8.12 p.m. Mrs. Hart cannot explain it and has retained the envelope.

JAMES HART / BROTHER / ACTING MANAGER

"I saw her near the front office at five. She said she was going away. She left by the river gate. I have not seen her since."

HENRY HART / BROTHER / APPRENTICE

"I was out with a delivery. Nell said she would show Uncle George something at tomorrow's meeting. She would not say what."

GEORGE HART / UNCLE / EXECUTOR

"A family meeting was arranged for ten this morning. Eleanor asked me not to settle the works before I had heard her. She sounded excited, not frightened."

Papers from Eleanor's writing desk supplied by Mrs. Hart. No conclusion as to a voluntary departure has been reached.